



Gold miners have cleared the forests and grasslands along the Nechi River in Colombia. The brightly colored pools pockmarking the area contain mining pollution.

HEALTH LAW LETS DOCTORS CASH IN

Patients' Safeguard Has Unintended Effect

By SARAH KLIFF and MARGOT SANGER-KATZ

WASHINGTON — Dr. Norman Rowe, a plastic surgeon with offices in New York and Florida, advertises on his website that breast reduction surgery usually costs \$15,000 to \$25,000.

But these days, his practice sometimes earns \$440,000 for the procedure.

Dr. Rowe has taken full advantage of a new arbitration system, part of a major consumer protection law Congress passed in 2020 with bipartisan majorities. The No Surprises Act was designed to eliminate surprise medical bills for patients who showed up in the emergency room and were treated by a doctor who didn't take their insurance.

It bars those out-of-network doctors from billing patients directly. Instead, they can plead their case to a government-approved arbitrator. If they win, the patient's insurer has to pay their desired amount.

By all accounts, the law is successfully protecting patients against bills from doctors they never chose. But it has also generated an expensive unanticipated consequence: Doctors have flooded the arbitration system with millions of claims. Most are winning, often collecting fees hundreds of times higher than what they could negotiate with insurers directly or what they could have earned from patients before the law passed.

"I'm still glad we passed the bill, because we got consumers out of it, but we need to rein in this arbitration process," said Representative Frank Pallone Jr., Democrat of New Jersey, who helped negotiate the law.

Some health plans said they have increased premiums this year to cover the extra costs. The United Service Workers health plan, which covers 20,000 trades workers in the New York area,

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U.S. Mint Buys Drug Cartel Gold and Sells It as 'American'

This article is by Justin Scheck, Simón Posada and Federico Rios.

CAUCASIA, Colombia — Every year, the United States Mint sells more than \$1 billion of investment-grade gold coins. Each is stamped with an icon like the bald eagle, signifying the government's guarantee, required by law, that the gold is 100 percent American.

"To hold a coin or medal produced by the Mint is to connect to the founding principles of our nation," the Mint declares.

But an investigation by The New York Times has found that the government's program of gold sales is based on a lie. The Mint is actually the last link in a chain that launders foreign gold, much of it illegally mined, for an insatiable market.

The Mint buys gold that originates in a Colombian drug cartel mine. It makes Lady Liberty coins out of gold from Mexican and Peruvian pawn shops and from a Congolese mine that is part-owned by the Chinese government, records show. Some Mint gold has come from a company in Honduras that dug up an Indigenous graveyard for the ore underneath.

Congress in 1985 prohibited the Mint from making bullion out of foreign gold because it wanted to insulate the process from human rights abuses, primarily in apartheid South Africa. The Mint has flouted that law, across Democratic and Republican administrations, despite internal warnings.

Now, even President Trump's 24-karat gold coin, commemorating the United States' 250th birthday, could come from a swirl of non-American gold from any number of sources.

The Mint, the biggest name in the global market for investment gold coins, is an example of how the industry's guardrails have collapsed. Gold prices hover around \$5,000 an ounce, about four times the price of a decade ago. That gives criminal organizations and fly-by-night operators a huge incentive to mine in wasteful, destructive and risky ways.

Investors buy gold as a hedge against instability. Nearly every terrorist attack, war and financial meltdown in the past quarter-century has fueled a gold-buying frenzy.

But as prices climb ever higher, wealthy buyers are actually helping to create the very instability they are trying to hedge against.

Gold mining funds Sudan's brutal civil war and Russia's invasion of Ukraine. Surging gold prices have helped Venezuela and Iran temper the effects of financial sanctions. Colombia's biggest cartel, the Clan del Golfo, traffics in

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Federal law requires coins like this to be minted only from newly mined American gold.



Netting is used to foil Russian drone attacks in Izium, a Ukrainian military hub in the Donbas.

Kyiv Floats Idea of Naming an Area 'Donnyland'

By ANTON TROIANOVSKI and ANDREW E. KRAMER

WASHINGTON — When Poland sought a U.S. military base in 2018, it pitched the idea as Fort Trump.

When Armenia and Azerbaijan signed a peace pledge at the White House last year, they called the transport link it created the Trump Route for International Peace and Prosperity.

But the most improbable instance of President Trump's name being lent to a geopolitical flashpoint may be one that has remained out of public view until now. In Ukraine peace talks in recent months, Ukrainian officials have suggested that the slice of the country's Donbas region that Russia is still fighting for could be named "Donnyland."

The moniker, a reference to "Donbas" and "Donald," was described by four people familiar with the negotiations, who all spoke about it on the condition of

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Peace-Seeking Appeal to Trump on Donbas

Peace and Prosperity.

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Jackson's Music Proves Too Big To Be Canceled by Scandals

By BEN SISARIO

Seven years ago, when two men made detailed, unsettling accusations in an HBO documentary that Michael Jackson had sexually abused them as boys, the music industry pondered a striking question: Could Jackson, one of the most popular and beloved artists of all time, really be canceled?

The answer, it turned out, was a resounding "no."

As the Jackson estate's latest megaproject, the Hollywood biopic "Michael," arrived this weekend, the King of Pop is more popular — and the business behind him more lucrative — than at any point since his 2009 death.

Streaming activity for his catalog of hits like "Thriller," "Billie Jean" and "Bad" rivals that of contemporary stars like Kendrick Lamar and Sabrina Carpenter. A Broadway musical, "MJ," once thought to be endangered by HBO's two-part documentary, "Leaving Neverland," has instead proved a sustained hit, selling 2.3 million tickets worth \$328 million since it started performances in late 2021, according to the Broadway League.



A biopic that casts Michael Jackson in a friendly light opened this weekend.

And every Halloween, you can reliably hear the synthesized beat and spooky sound effects of "Thriller" booming out of school parking lots and trick-or-treat houses all across the U.S.

Perhaps more than any other performer, Jackson has repeatedly had his reputation tested, but the music he made has endured, and even thrived. That is as much

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NATIONAL 16-25

High-Profile New York Race

In a City Council district that is home to Stonewall and many L.G.B.T.Q. residents, a straight person could win for the first time since 1991.

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Costs Rise for Summer Travel

Facing jet fuel shortages linked to the war in Iran, airlines are cutting routes and increasing fees and fares.

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SUNDAY BUSINESS

In Search of Bitcoin's Creator

The inventor of the cryptocurrency has hidden behind a pseudonym for years. A trail of clues led to one name.

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INTERNATIONAL 4-14

Another Layer for Chernobyl

There are ways the contaminated zone could bring Ukraine economic benefits. The war is complicating them.

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The Widow Snagged by ICE

Marie-Thérèse Ross-Mahé, 85, who had been married to a former G.I., recounted her weeks in detention.

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METROPOLITAN

The Subway's Secret Rooms

Transit officials are spending billions to upgrade New York City's electrical substations, the mostly invisible backbone of the subway system.

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ARTS & LEISURE

'Fear' on Death Row

Adrien Brody and Tessa Thompson headline "The Fear of 13," a play about an unjustly imprisoned man.

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At the 'Baywatch' Tryouts

A revival of the television series drew aspirants of all ages in a sea of red swimsuits.

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SPECIAL SECTION

It's Time to Plan a Wedding

Today's nuptials are no longer simply one-size-fits-all events. Here's a guide to creating a celebration unique to you.

SUNDAY STYLES

A Presidential Look, for Men

In Donald J. Trump's orbit, women are not the only ones who are concerned about their appearances.

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Hot Brands Arrive From Asia

Newish-to-the-West labels from Japan, like A.Presse, Comoli, Auralee and T.T., are changing men's wear.

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SUNDAY OPINION

Ben Rhodes

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